

Bloody Missouri

This problem was most manifest in the border state of Missouri, which had a mix of extreme secessionist enclaves and pro-Union communities supported by loyal Kansas militias and occupying Federal troops. A miniature civil war broke out in the absence of formal military operations, and the barbarities committed by both sides were extreme.

When some sisters and wives of men in the band of notorious guerrilla leader William C. Quantrill died while incarcerated by Union authorities, the enraged Quantrill brought together every Confederate guerrilla group in Missouri he could find and led 450 men on a raid of revenge against the Free-Soil town of Lawrence, Kansas. On August 21, 1863, Quantrill and his men reached the unprotected hamlet, deep in Union territory. He ordered, "Kill every male and burn every house." Three hours later, 182 men and boys lay dead and 185 buildings had burned to the ground. Union reprisals failed to track down many of those responsible, but succeeded in killing and burning out even more civilians. In Missouri, the Civil War was also a war on civilians.

Because of the escalating difficulties in dealing with Confederate guerrillas, Union officers began to take matters more and more into their own hands. Guerrillas caught destroying Federal property were frequently shot on sight, and captured irregulars were often killed "while trying to escape." Disloyal civilians were blacklisted and had their freedoms curtailed.

Increasingly, the treatment of Southern civilians and irregular fighters depended on the judgment of the local Union commander. The War Department began to follow their lead in late 1862, calling all Southern guerrillas "the common enemies of mankind [to be] hunted and shot without challenge wherever found."